

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

DOW JONES | News Corp

THURSDAY, APRIL 16, 2026 ~ VOL. CCLXXXVII NO. 88

WSJ.com

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DJIA 48463.72 ▼ 72.27 0.15% NASDAQ 24016.02 ▲ 1.6% STOXX 600 617.27 ▼ 0.4% 10-YR. TREAS. ▼ 6/32, yield 4.279% OIL \$91.29 ▲ \$0.01 GOLD \$4,800.00 ▼ \$25.00 EURO \$1.1800 YEN 158.98

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Trump said he wouldn't** abandon the Justice Department's criminal investigation of Fed Chair Jerome Powell and threatened to fire him if he doesn't resign when his term as central bank leader ends next month. **A1**
- ◆ **Surging tech stocks** carried the S&P 500 and Nasdaq to new records as the indexes rose 0.8% and 1.6%, respectively, while the Dow industrials slipped 0.1%. **B9**
- ◆ **A jury found that** Live Nation illegally monopolized the ticketing market for major concerts in the U.S., in a win for a group of states that had brought the suit. **A1**
- ◆ **Economists surveyed** on the effects of the Iran war projected higher inflation, slower near-term growth and weaker job creation. **A2**
- ◆ **The energy-price shock** from the war falls between the ECB's baseline and adverse scenarios, the bank's president, Christine Lagarde, said. **A8**
- ◆ **Hermès shares dropped** by as much as 14% after the Parisian fashion house reported weaker-than-expected first-quarter sales growth. **B1**
- ◆ **Snap said it plans** to cut around 1,000 jobs, or roughly 16% of its full-time workforce, as the company pursues profitable growth. **B3**
- ◆ **The European Union** plans to order Meta Platforms to reverse a policy that officials say effectively bans rival AI chatbots from using its WhatsApp platform. **B4**
- ◆ **ASML raised its sales** guidance for the year as chip makers continue to spend billions of dollars on the company's machines. **B4**

Worldwide

- ◆ **The Trump administration** encouraged automakers and other American manufacturers to play a larger role in weapons production, recalling a practice used during World War II. **A1**
- ◆ **Supreme Court Justice** Sonia Sotomayor publicly apologized to Justice Brett Kavanaugh after suggesting last week that he didn't know any blue-collar workers because he had a privileged upbringing. **A4**
- ◆ **The FTC and eight states** reached a proposed settlement with ad companies to resolve whether the firms erred by coordinating boycotts against media platforms. **A3**
- ◆ **The IRS chief told** the Senate Finance Committee that the agency would pursue tax cheats without bias, even with a smaller staff. **A6**
- ◆ **The Trump administration** authorized more H-2B visas for guest workers after a lobbying campaign by industry leaders and a member of Congress. **A6**
- ◆ **A Yale internal report** counseled the university to check liberal bias, introduce more merit in admissions and reduce preferences for legacies. **A3**
- ◆ **The Justice Department** asked an appeals court to throw out the seditious conspiracy convictions of Proud Boys and Oath Keepers leaders connected to the Jan. 6 Capitol riot. **A4**
- ◆ **New York Gov.** Kathy Hochul proposed a tax on second homes in New York City worth \$5 million or more in an effort to fill the city's budget deficit. **A4**
- ◆ **Died: Mark Mobius**, 89, early champion of emerging-markets investing. **B5**

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Pope Blasts 'Chains of Corruption' on Africa Trip



BLUNT GUEST: Pope Leo urged Cameroon to break 'the chains of corruption, which disfigure authority and strip it of credibility.' President Paul Biya, who won an October contested election, and his wife, Chantal, hosted the pope in Yaoundé on Wednesday. **A10**

Pentagon Courts U.S. Industry To Boost Weapons Production

Top defense officials have held discussions with automakers, other manufacturers

By Sharon Terlep
And Marcus Weisgerber

The Trump administration wants automakers and other U.S. manufacturers to play a larger role in weapons production reminiscent of a practice

used during World War II. Senior defense officials have held talks about producing weapons and other military supplies with chief executives of several U.S. manufacturers, including GM's Mary Barra and Ford Motor's Jim Farley, people familiar with the discussions said. The Pentagon is interested in enlisting the companies to use their employees and factory capacity to increase production of munitions and

other equipment after the wars in Ukraine and Iran have depleted stocks. The talks with the companies were preliminary and wide ranging, the people said. Defense officials said U.S. manufacturers might be needed to backstop traditional defense firms and asked whether the companies could rapidly shift to defense work. GE Aerospace and vehicle and machinery maker Oshkosh were also among the compa-

nies involved in the talks with defense officials. The Defense Department "is committed to rapidly expanding the defense industrial base by leveraging all available commercial solutions and technologies to ensure our warfighters maintain a decisive advantage," a Pentagon official said. The discussions are the latest by the administration to put military manufacturing on what Defense Secretary Pete

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Iran's Radical New Leaders

The war fast-tracked the ascent of hard-liners and apocalyptic religious followers

By Margherita Stancati,
Benoit Faucon
and Henna Moussavi

On March 13, a massive billboard appeared in Tehran's Enghelab Square. It showed Iran's newly selected supreme leader, Mojtaba Khamenei, standing in a trench and instructing commanders of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps to fire missiles at their enemies. The text suggested the mission is divinely inspired, comparing Khamenei to Imam Ali, a revered Muslim figure known for his legendary vic-

tory over Jewish tribes. For opponents of Iran's regime, the image is the visual representation of their worst nightmare: a militarized Iran ruled by a younger, hard-line

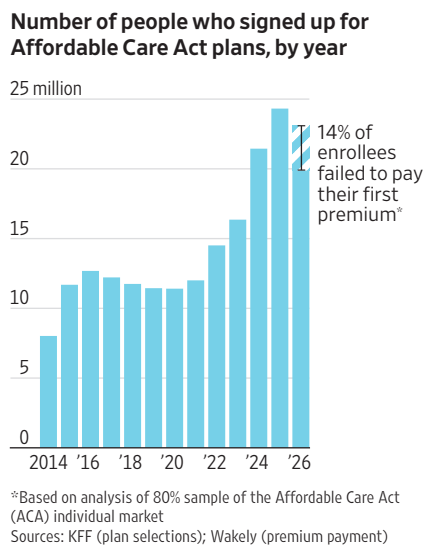
leader where the Revolutionary Guard plays an even more dominant role. The U.S. and Israel launched the war with the hope that killing top Iranian officials—starting with Mojtaba's father, Ali Khamenei—would create the conditions for regime change or at least the emergence of leaders more

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◆ **Trump aims to force quick deal.....** **A9**

ACA Hit As Bills Unpaid

One in seven people who signed up for Affordable Care Act plans this year failed to pay after premium costs rose sharply, according to an analysis that provides the first comprehensive look at the impact of expiring federal subsidies. **A3**



Jury Finds Live Nation Holds Illegal Ticket-Sales Monopoly

A federal jury on Wednesday found that Live Nation illegally monopolized the ticketing market for major concerts in the U.S., in a win for a group of states that accused it of overcharging music fans and pressuring venues to use its dominant ticketing service, Ticketmaster. The verdict came after five weeks of trial and nearly four days of deliberation by jurors in federal court in Manhattan. The Justice Department made the decision last month to settle its case against Live Nation, leaving more than 30 states to try their claims without the federal government. Now, the group of states will likely try to persuade a judge during a new phase of pro-

ceedings that splitting up Live Nation is the only way to fix a broken market. Consumers who were overcharged for tickets will be eligible to get money back, but the total Live Nation will pay hasn't been determined yet. Live Nation shares closed down more than 6% after the verdict was read. Shares of ticketing rival StubHub rose by nearly 4%, while Vivid Seats

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Wall Street's Top Coffee Tasters Are Looking for New Recruits

Elite force of bean sniffers and java sippers helps set the U.S. futures market for arabica

By Krystal Hur

The people who gather in this small room on the eighth floor of the New York Stock Exchange look like a group of middle-aged caffeine addicts. They sit around what resembles a school science lab sniffing coffee beans and slurping coffee so aggressively that there's loud music

playing to drown them out. But these aren't junkies with bad manners. They're part of an elite team of graders who help keep the commodities market running. Their ratings help set U.S. futures-market prices for arabica, and in turn, the global coffee industry. And they've arguably never been more valuable.

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Brew crew

LIV Golf on the Brink As Saudis Eye Pullout

By Andrew Beaton

The breakaway faction that split the golf world in two is on the verge of surrender. Saudi Arabia's sovereign-wealth fund is close to abandoning its backing of LIV Golf after years of hemorrhaging money and struggling to find a meaningful television audience, according to a person familiar with the matter. Launched in 2022, LIV lured in a collection of stars from the established PGA Tour by committing billions of dollars and plunged the sleepy busi-

ness of men's professional golf into cutthroat competition. As Saudi Arabia's Public Investment Fund considered pulling the plug, more than 50 LIV players were in Mexico on Wednesday ahead of a mid-season tournament due to begin on Thursday. With players on the grounds at the Club de Golf Chapultepec, outside Mexico City, rumors swirled about when they might receive a final decision, another person familiar with the matter said. As the Saudis weighed a

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INSIDE



PERSONAL JOURNAL
Americans are getting big tax cuts—whether they know it or not. **A13**